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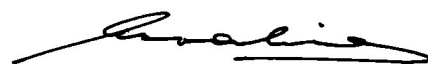


It is always difficult to pigeonhole a year into one theme, but 2007 can undoubtedly be a 'Year of Confrontation'. Not the battlefield kind with real blood but most of the time a little more civilised. The overarching confrontation which dominated the year was the peculiar one between the Congress and its Left allies over the Indo-US nuclear deal. Fortunately, it was fought in the drawing rooms and not in the streets but it was a conflict between so-called friends. Ironically it was the members of the coalition who opposed the deal rather than the official Opposition, the BJP. Sadly, the bedraggled BJP spent the year desperately looking for a confrontation but without much luck. Finally, they got one in Gujarat in December and even that was not really theirs. It was more Chief Minister Narendra Modi and Congress chief Sonia Gandhi trading on the 'Merchant of Death' theme.

Elsewhere, it was Mamata Bannerjee versus Buddhadeb Bhattacharya over Nandigram which turned violent, the age-old confrontation between Mayawati and Mulayam Singh took on a personal edge in the Uttar Pradesh polls. Karunanidhi made public his distancing from one-time favourite nephew Dayanidhi Maran, while Rajasthan Chief Minister Vasundhara Raje faced the biggest opposition from Jaswant Singh, a senior of her own party. In the cultural field, we saw Information and Broadcasting minister Priya Ranjan Dasmunshi on collision course with the media over the proposed Broadcasting Bill, filmdom was not far behind with not so subtle sniping at each other between Amitabh Bachchan and Shah Rukh Khan followed by the box office clash between *Saawariya* and *Om Shanti Om*. And in sports, where gladiatorial contests are expected, the defining theme was the clash for control of India's lucrative cricketing market between BCCI and the newly promoted Indian Cricket League.

Surprisingly, the field which matters the most, the economy, had very little confrontation. It grew at a merry pace of 9 per cent in spite of all the political haggling. The stock market hit a new high and foreign money continued to pour in the billions. Perhaps, there was a message in this for all our squabbling politicians. After all, they don't seem to matter that much any more.

With that in mind, I wish you a peaceful, happy and prosperous new year.


(Aroon Purie)